

The next two notes tie together two topics that may at first sight appear to have nothing to do with each

other: the nature of infinity (和 more particularly, the distinction between different levels of infinity), 和

thefundamentalnatureofcomputationandproof.

Inthisfirstnotewewillfocusonnotionsofinfinity, 和

thenturntoconnectionswithcomputationinthesecondnote.

1 Bijections

Twofinitesetshavethesame size if and only if their elements can be paired up, so that each element of one set has a unique partner in the other set, and vice versa.

We formalize this through the concept of a bijection.

考虑 a 函数 (或 mapping) f that maps elements of a 集合 A (called the 定义域 of f) to elements of

set B (called the range of f). 因为 f

is a function, it must specify, for each element $x \in A$ (“input”), exactly

one 元素 $f(x) \in B$ (“output”). 回忆 we write this as $f : A \rightarrow B$. We say

that f is a bijection 如果

every 元素 $a \in A$ has a unique image $b = f(a) \in B$, 和 every 元素 $b \in B$

has a unique pre-image

$a \in A$: $f(a) = b$.

f is a one-to-one function (or an injection) 如果 f

maps distinct inputs to distinct outputs. More precisely, f is

one-to-one if the following holds: ($x \in A$) ($y \in A$) ($x \neq y \implies f(x) \neq f(y)$).

f

is onto (or surjective) if it “hits” every element in the range (i.e., each element in the range has at least one pre-image). More precisely, a function f

is onto if the following holds: ($y \in B$) ($x \in A$) ($f(x) = y$).

Here are some simple examples to help visualize one-to-one and onto functions, and bijections:

One-to-one Onto Both (bijection)

1 a 1 a 1 a

b 2 2 b

2 b

c 3 3 c

3 d 4 c 4 d

A B A B A B

A B A B A B

A B A B A B

Not that, according to the above definitions, f

is a bijection if and only if it is both one-to-one and onto.

练习. 令 $f : A \rightarrow B$ be a bijection. Show that f has an inverse

$f^{-1} : B \rightarrow A$ that satisfies $f^{-1}(f(a)) = a$

for all $a \in A$, and that f^{-1} is also a bijection.

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2 Cardinality

How can we determine whether two sets have the same cardinality (或 “size”)?

The answer to this question,

reassuringly, lies in early grade school memories:

by demonstrating a pairing between elements of the two

sets. More formally, we need to demonstrate a bijection f

between the two sets. The bijection sets up a

one-to-one correspondence, or pairing, between elements of the two sets.

We’ve seen above how this works

for finite sets.

In the rest of this lecture, we will see what it tells us about infinite sets.

Our first 问题 about 无限的 sets is the following: Are there more natural numbers $\mathbb{N}$ than 存在

positive integers $\mathbb{Z}^+$?

It is tempting to answer yes, since every positive integer is also a natural number, 但是 the natural numbers have one extra element $0 \in \mathbb{Z}^+$.

Upon more careful observation, though, we see that we

can define a bijection between the natural numbers and the positive integers as follows:

$\mathbb{N}$ 0 1 2 3 4 5 ...

f

$\mathbb{Z}^+$ 1 2 3 4 5 6 ...

More precisely, this mapping is defined by $f(n) = n+1$ 对所有 $n \in \mathbb{N}$.

Why is this mapping a bijection?

Clearly, the 函数 $f: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}^+$ is onto because every 正的 整数 is hit.

和 it is also one-to-one

because not two natural numbers have the same image. (The image of n is

$f(n) = n+1$, 所以 如果 $f(n) = f(m)$)

那么 we must have $n = m$.) 因为 我们有 shown a bijection between $\mathbb{N}$ 和

$\mathbb{Z}^+$, this tells us that 存在

as many natural numbers as there are positive integers!

(Very) informally, we have proved that " $\infty + 1 = \infty$."

What about the 集合 of even natural numbers $2\mathbb{N} = \{0, 2, 4, 6, \dots\}$?

In the previous 例子 the difference

was just one element.

But in this example, there seem to be twice as many natural numbers as there are even natural numbers.

Surely, the cardinality of $\mathbb{N}$ must be larger than that of $2\mathbb{N}$ since $\mathbb{N}$ contains all of the odd natural numbers as well?

Though it might seem to be a more difficult task, let us attempt to find a bijection

between the two sets using the following mapping, $f(n) = 2n$ for all $n \in \mathbb{N}$:

$\mathbb{N}$ 0 1 2 3 4 5 ...

f

$2\mathbb{N}$ 0 2 4 6 8 10 ...

The mapping in this 例子 is also a bijection. f is clearly

one-to-one, 因为 distinct natural numbers get

mapped to distinct even natural numbers (since $2n = 2m$ implies $n = m$). f

is also onto, since every n in the

range is hit: its pre-image is $n/2$.

Since we have found a bijection between the two sets, this tells us that in

2

fact $\mathbb{N}$ and $2\mathbb{N}$ have the same cardinality!

What about the 集合 of all integers, $\mathbb{Z}$? At first glance, it

may seem obvious that the 集合 of integers is larger

than the set of natural numbers, since it includes infinitely many negative numbers.

然而, as it turns out,

it is possible to find a bijection between the two sets, meaning that the two sets have the same size!

考虑

the following mapping f :

... ...

0 1 2 3 4 124

0 1 1 2 2 ... 62 ...

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In other words, our function is defined as follows:

x

if x is even

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} 2x & \text{if } x \text{ is odd} \\ 2x+1 & \text{if } x \text{ is even} \end{cases}$$

if x is odd

2

We will 证明 that this 函数 $f: \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$ is a bijection, by first showing that it is one-to-one 和 那么

showing that it is onto.

证明 (one-to-one): 假设 $f(x) = f(y)$. 那么 they both must have the same sign. 因此 either

$f(x) = 2x$ 和 $f(y) = 2y$, 或 $f(x) = 2x+1$ 和 $f(y) = 2y+1$. In the first case,

2 2 2 2

$x = y$

$$f(x) = f(y) \implies 2x = 2y \implies x = y.$$

2 2

In the second case,

$x+1 = y+1$

$$f(x) = f(y) \implies 2x+1 = 2y+1 \implies x = y.$$

2 2

So in both cases $f(x) = f(y) \implies x = y$, 所以 f is injective.

证明 (onto): If $y \in \mathbb{Z}$ is non-negative, 那么 $f(2y) = y$. 因此, y has a pre-image.

If y is negative, 那么

$f(2y+1) = y$. 因此, y has a pre-image. Thus every $y \in \mathbb{Z}$ has a pre-image, 所以

f is onto.

因为 f is a bijection, this tells us that $\mathbb{N}$ and $\mathbb{Z}$ have the same size.

Now for an important definition.

Definition 10.1.

We say that a set S is countable if there is a bijection between S and $\mathbb{N}$ or some subset of $\mathbb{N}$.

因此 any 有限的 集合 S is countable (因为 存在 a bijection between S 和 the 子集 $\{0, 1, 2, \dots, m-1\}$,

where $m = |S|$ is the size of S).

And we have already seen three examples of countable infinite sets: $\mathbb{Z}^+$

和

$\mathbb{N}$ are obviously countable since they are themselves subsets of $\mathbb{N}$; and $\mathbb{Z}$ is countable because we have just seen a bijection between it and $\mathbb{N}$.

What about the 集合 of all 有理数 numbers? 回忆 $\mathbb{Q} = \{x/y \mid x, y \in \mathbb{Z}, y \neq 0\}$.

Surely 存在 more

y

有理数 numbers than natural numbers? After all, 存在 infinitely

many 有理数 numbers between any

two natural numbers. Surprisingly, the two sets have the

same cardinality! To see this, 令 us introduce a

slightly different way of comparing the cardinality of two sets.

If there is a one-to-one function f

$A \rightarrow B$, then the cardinality of A is less than or equal to that of B . Now to

show that the cardinality of A and B are the same we can show that $|A| \leq |B|$ 和 $|B| \leq |A|$.

This corresponds

to showing that there is a one-to-one function f

$A \rightarrow B$ and a one-to-one function $g: B \rightarrow A$. The existence

of these two one-to-one functions implies that there is a bijection $h: A \rightarrow B$, thus showing that A and B have the same cardinality. The proof of this fact,

which is called the Cantor-Bernstein theorem, is actually quite

hard, and we will skip it here.

Back to comparing the natural numbers 和 the integers. First

it is obvious that $|\mathbb{N}| \leq |\mathbb{Q}|$ because $\mathbb{N} \subseteq \mathbb{Q}$.

所以 our goal now is to 证明 that also $|Q| \leq |N|$. To do this, we must exhibit an injection $f: Q \rightarrow N$. The following picture of a spiral conveys the idea of this injection:
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```

3
2
1
 3  2  1 1 2 3
 1
 2
 3

```

Each rational number a/b (written in its lowest terms, so that $\gcd(a, b) = 1$) is represented by the point (a, b) in the infinite two-dimensional grid shown (where $(0, 0)$ corresponds to 0 , the set of all pairs of integers).

Notice that not all points on the grid are valid representations of rationals: e.g., all points on the x -axis have $b = 0$ so none are valid (except for $(0, 0)$, which we take to represent the rational number 0); and points such as $(2, 8)$ and $(-1, -4)$ are not valid either as the rational number $1/4$ is represented by $(1, 4)$. But $Z \times Z$

certainly contains all rationals under this representation, so if we come up with an injection from $Z \times Z$ to N then this will also be an injection from Q to N (why?).

The idea is to map each pair (a, b) to its position along the spiral, starting at the origin. (Therefore, e.g., $(0, 0) \rightarrow 0$, $(1, 0) \rightarrow 1$, $(1, 1) \rightarrow 2$, $(0, 1) \rightarrow 3$, and so on.) It should be clear that this mapping maps every pair of integers

injectively to a natural number, because each pair occupies a unique position along the spiral. This tells us that $|Q| \leq |N|$. Since also $|N| \leq |Q|$, as we observed earlier, by the Cantor–Bernstein Theorem N and Q have the same cardinality.

练习. Show that the set $N \times N$ of all ordered pairs of natural numbers is countable. Our next example concerns the set of all binary strings (of any finite length), denoted $\{0, 1\}^*$. Despite the

fact that this set contains strings of unbounded length, it turns out to have the same cardinality as N . To see

this, we set up a direct bijection $f: \{0, 1\}^* \rightarrow N$ as follows. Note that it suffices to enumerate the elements of $\{0, 1\}^*$

in such a way that each string appears exactly once in the list. We then get our bijection by setting $f(n)$ to be the n th string in the list. How do we enumerate the strings in $\{0, 1\}^*$? Well, it's natural to list them

in increasing order of length, and then (say) in lexicographic order (or, equivalently, numerically increasing order when viewed as binary numbers) within the strings of each length. This means that the list would look like $\epsilon, 0, 1, 00, 01, 10, 11, 000, 001, 010, 011, 100, 101, 110, 111, 0000, \dots$ where ϵ denotes the empty string (the only string of length 0). It should be clear that this list contains each

binary string once and only once, so we get a bijection with $\mathbb{N}$ as desired.

Our final countable example is the set of all polynomials with natural number coefficients, which we denote $\mathbb{N}(x)$. To see that this 集合 is countable, we will make use of (a variant of) the previous 例子. 笔记 first

that, by essentially the same argument as for $\{0, 1\}$, we can see that the set of all ternary strings $\{0, 1, 2\}$ (that is, strings over the alphabet $\{0, 1, 2\}$) is countable.

To see that $\mathbb{N}(x)$ is countable, it therefore suffices to

exhibit an injection f

$:\mathbb{N}(x) \rightarrow \{0, 1, 2\}^*$, which in turn will give an injection from $\mathbb{N}(x)$ to $\mathbb{N}$.

(It is obvious

that 存在 an injection from $\mathbb{N}$ to $\mathbb{N}(x)$, 因为 each natural number

n is itself trivially a 多项式,

namely the constant polynomial n itself.)

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How do we define f ?

Let's first consider an example, namely the polynomial $p(x) = 5x^5 + 2x^4 + 7x^3 + 4x + 6$.

We can list the coefficients of $p(x)$ as follows: $(5, 2, 7, 0, 4, 6)$.

We can then write these coefficients as binary

strings: $(101, 10, 111, 0, 100, 110)$. Now, we can construct a

ternary string 其中 a "2" is inserted as a

separator between each binary coefficient (ignoring coefficients that are 0).

Thus we map $p(x)$ to a ternary

string as illustrated below:

$5x^5 + 2x^4 + 7x^3 + 4x + 6$

1012102111221002110

It is easy to check that this is an injection, since the original polynomial can be uniquely recovered from this ternary string by simply reading off the coefficients

between each successive pair of 2's. (Notice that this

mapping $f : \mathbb{N}(x) \rightarrow \{0, 1, 2\}^*$

is not onto (and hence not a bijection) since many ternary strings will not be

the image of any polynomial; this will be the case, for example, for any ternary strings that contain binary subsequences with leading zeros.)

Hence we have an injection from $\mathbb{N}(x)$ to $\mathbb{N}$, so $\mathbb{N}(x)$ is countable.

3 Cantor's Diagonalization

我们已 established that $\mathbb{N}$, $\mathbb{Z}$, $\mathbb{Q}$ all have the same cardinality.

What about $\mathbb{R}$, the 集合 of 实数 numbers?

Surely they are countable too?

After all, the rational numbers, like the real numbers, are dense (i.e., between

any two 有理数 numbers a, b 存在 a 有理数 number, 即 $a+b$). In fact,

between any two 实数

2

numbers there is always a rational number.

It is really surprising, 那么, that there are more real numbers than rationals.

That is, there is no bijection between the rationals (or the natural numbers) and the reals.

We shall

now prove this, using a beautiful argument due to Cantor that is known as diagonalization.

In fact, we will

show something even stronger:

the real numbers in the interval $[0, 1]$ are uncountable!

练习.

Show how to find a rational number between any two (distinct) real numbers.

In preparation 对于 the 证明, 回忆 any 实数 number can be written

out uniquely as an 无限的 decimal

with no trailing zeros. In particular, a 实数 number in the interval $[0,1]$ can be written as $0.d_1d_2d_3\dots$. In

this representation, we write for example 1 as $0.999\dots$, and 0.5 as $0.4999\dots$. (Thus rational numbers will

always be represented as recurring decimals, while irrational ones will be represented as non-recurring ones.

Importantly for us, all of these expressions will be infinitely long and unique.)
Theorem 10.1.

The real interval $\mathbb{R}[0,1]$ (and hence also the set of real numbers $\mathbb{R}$) is uncountable.

证明. 假设 towards a 矛盾 that 存在 a bijection $f:\mathbb{N}\rightarrow\mathbb{R}[0,1]$. 那么, we can enumerate

the real numbers in an infinite list $f(0), f(1), f(2), \dots$ as follows:

$f(0) = 0.52149356\dots$

$f(1) = 0.14162985\dots$

$f(2) = 0.94782712\dots$

$f(3) = 0.53098175\dots$

$\dots$

$\dots$

$\dots$

To see this, write $x = 0.999\dots$. Then $10x = 9.999\dots$, so $9x = 9$, and thus $x = 1$.

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Now 考虑 the 实数 number r whose 无限的 decimal expansion is 给定 by the diagonal elements in the

表 above (circled in the diagram): 即, $r = 0.5479\dots$. We use r to construct a new 实数 number s

obtained by modifying every digit of r , say by replacing each digit d with $d+2 \pmod{10}$; 因此 in our example above, $s = 0.7691\dots$.

We claim that s does not occur in our infinite list of real numbers. 假设

对于 矛盾 that it did, 和 that it was the n th number in the list, $f(n)$. 但是 通过构造 s differs

from $f(n)$ in the $(n+1)$ th digit, 所以 these two numbers cannot be equal! 所以 我们有 constructed a 实数

number s 即 非 in the 值域 of f . 但是 this contradicts the assertion that f is a bijection. 因此 the 实数

numbers are not countable.

令 us 注 that the reason that we modified each digit by adding 2 (模 10) as opposed to adding 1 is

that the same 实数 number can have two decimal expansions; 对于 例子 $0.999\dots = 1.000\dots$. 但是 如果 two

实数 numbers differ by more than 1 in any digit they cannot be equal. 因此 we are completely safe in our

assertion. (An alternative way of avoiding this potential pitfall is to replace each digit by some different digit chosen from the range $\{1, 2, \dots, 8\}$.)

With Cantor's diagonalization method, we proved that $\mathbb{R}$ is uncountable. 因为 我们有 obtained dramati-

cally different results 对于 $\mathbb{R}$ 和 对于 $\mathbb{Q}$ (the first is uncountable, the second is countable), we should really

go back and consider what goes wrong if we apply the diagonalization method to $\mathbb{Q}$, in an attempt to show

the rationals in the interval $[0,1]$ are uncountable. Well, suppose for contradiction that our bijective function $f:\mathbb{N}\rightarrow\mathbb{Q}[0,1]$ produces the following mapping:

$f(0) = 0.14000\dots$

$f(1) = 0.59245\dots$
 $f(2) = 0.21421\dots$
 $\dots$
 $\dots$
 $\dots$

This time, let us consider the number q obtained by modifying every digit of the diagonal, say by replacing each digit d with $d+2 \pmod{10}$.

Then in the above example $q = 0.316\dots$, and we want to try to show that it does not occur in our infinite list of rational numbers.

然而, we do not know that q is rational (in fact, it is extremely unlikely for the decimal expansion of q to be periodic). This is why the method fails when applied to the rationals.

When dealing with the reals, the modified diagonal number was guaranteed to be a real number.

4 The Cantor 集合

The Cantor 集合 is a remarkable 集合 construction involving the real numbers in the interval $[0, 1]$. The 集合 is defined by repeatedly removing the middle thirds of line segments infinitely many times, starting with the original interval. 对于例子, the first iteration would involve the removal of the (open) interval $(1/3, 2/3)$,

leaving $[0, 1/3] \cup [2/3, 1]$.

We then proceed to remove the middle third of each of the set of remaining intervals,

and soon. The first three iterations are illustrated below:

$0 \leq x \leq 1$
 1) $[0, 1]$
 2) $[0, 1/3] \cup [2/3, 1]$
 3) $[0, 1/9] \cup [2/9, 1/3] \cup [2/3, 7/9] \cup [8/9, 1]$

The Cantor 集合 contains all points that have not been removed:

$C = \{x : x \text{ not removed}\}$. How much of the original unit interval is left after this process is repeated infinitely? Well, we start with an interval of length 1, and after the first iteration we remove $1/3$ of it, leaving us with $2/3$. For the second iteration, we keep $2/3$ of the original interval. As we repeat these iterations infinitely often, we are left with:

$1 \times (2/3)^n$
 $1 \times (2/3)^n \rightarrow 0$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$
 $1 \times (2/3)^n \rightarrow 0$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$

According to the calculations, we have removed everything from the original interval!

Does this mean that

the Cantor 集合 is empty? No, it doesn't. What it means is that the measure of the Cantor 集合 is zero; the Cantor 集合 consists of isolated points and does not contain any non-trivial intervals. In fact, not only is the Cantor set non-empty, it is uncountable!

To see why, let us first make a few observations about ternary strings.

In ternary notation, all strings consist of digits (called "trits") from the set $\{0, 1, 2\}$. All real numbers in the interval $[0, 1]$ can be written in

ternary notation. (E.g., 1 can be written as 0.1, 或 equivalently as 0.0222..., 和 2 can be written as 0.2 3 3 或 as 0.1222....) 因此, in the first iteration, the middle third removed contains all ternary numbers of the form 0.1xxxxx. The ternary numbers left after the first removal can all be expressed either in the form 0.0xxxxx... 或 0.2xxxxx... (我们有 to be a little careful here with the endpoints of the intervals; 但是 we can handle them by writing 1 as 0.02222... 和 2 as 0.2.) The second iteration removes ternary numbers

3 3 of the form 0.01xxxxx 和 0.21xxxxx (i.e., any number with 1 in the second position). The third iteration removes 1's in the third position, 和 所以 on. 因此, what remains is all ternary numbers with only 0's and 2's. Thus we have shown that

$C = \{x \in [0, 1] : x \text{ has a ternary representation consisting only of } 0' \text{ s and } 2' \text{ s}\}$. Finally, using this characterization, we can set up an onto map f from C to $[0, 1]$. Since we already know that $[0, 1]$ is uncountable, this implies that C is uncountable also. The map f is defined as follows: for $x \in C$, $f(x)$

is defined as the binary decimal obtained by dividing each digit of the ternary representation of x by 2. 因此,

对于 例子, 如果 $x = 0.0220$ (in ternary), 那么 $f(x)$ is the binary decimal 0.0110. 但是 the 集合 of all binary decimals $0.xxxxx...$ is in 1-1 correspondence with the 实数 interval $[0, 1]$, 和 the map f is onto because every binary decimal is the image of some ternary string under f (obtained by doubling every binary digit). This completes the proof that C is uncountable.

5 Power Sets 和 Higher Orders of Infinity

Let S be any set. Then the powerset of S , denoted by $P(S)$, is the set of all subsets of S . More formally, it is defined as: $P(S) = \{T : T \subseteq S\}$. 对于 例子, 如果 $S = \{1, 2, 3\}$, 那么 $P(S) = \{\{\}, \{1\}, \{2\}, \{3\}, \{1, 2\}, \{1, 3\}, \{2, 3\}, \{1, 2, 3\}\}$.

What is the cardinality of $P(S)$? 如果 $|S| = k$ is 有限的, 那么 $|P(S)| = 2^k$. To see this, 令 us think of each

subset of S corresponding to a k -bit string, where a 1 in the i th position indicates that the i th element of S is in the subset, and a 0 indicates that it is not.

In the example above, the subset $\{1, 3\}$ corresponds to the string 101. Now the number of binary strings of length k is 2^k , 因为 存在 two choices 对于 each bit position.

因此 $|P(S)| = 2^k$. So for finite sets S , the cardinality of the powerset of S is exponentially larger than the

2 It's actually easy to see that C contains at least countably many points, 即 the endpoints of the intervals in the

construction—i.e., numbers such as $1/3, 2/3, 1/9, 2/9, 1/27, 2/27, 1/81, 2/81$ etc. It's less obvious that C also contains various other points, such as $1/4$ 和

3 3 9 27 4

3. (Why?)

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3Notethat f is not injective;
 for example, the ternary strings $0.20222\dots$ and 0.22 map to binary strings $0.10111\dots$ and 0.11
 respectively, which denote the same real number. 因此 f
 is not a bijection. 然而, the current proof shows that the cardinality

of C is at least that of $[0, 1]$, while it is obvious that the cardinality of C is at most that of $[0, 1]$ since $C \subseteq [0, 1]$.
 Hence C has the
 same cardinality as $[0, 1]$ (and as $\mathbb{R}$).
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cardinality of S . What about 无限的 (countable) sets? We claim
 that 存在 no bijection from S to $P(S)$,
 so $P(S)$ is not countable.

Thus for example the set of all subsets of natural numbers is not countable, even
 though the set of natural numbers itself is countable.

Theorem 10.2. $|P(N)| > |N|$.

证明. Suppose towards a contradiction that there is a bijection f

$: N \rightarrow P(N)$. Recall that we can represent

a 子集 by a binary string, with one bit 对于 each 元素 of N . (所以,

因为 N is 无限的, the string will be

infinitely long. Contrast the case of $\{0, 1\}$ discussed

earlier, 其中 consists of all binary strings of 有限的

length.) 考虑 the following diagonalization picture in 其中 the

函数 f maps natural numbers x to

binary strings which correspond to subsets of N :

```
...
0 1 2 3 4 5
...
0 1 0 0 0 0 0
...
1 0 0 0 0 0 0
...
2 1 0 1 0 0 0
.
.
.
```

In this 例子, 我们有 assigned the following mapping: $0 \mapsto \{0\}$, $1 \mapsto \{\}$,

$2 \mapsto \{0, 2\}$, ... (i.e., the n th

row describes the n th 子集 as follows: 如果 存在 a 1 in the k th

column, 那么 k is in this 子集, else it is

非.) Using a similar diagonalization argument to the earlier

one, flip each bit along the diagonal: $1 \mapsto 0$,

$0 \mapsto 1$, and let b denote the resulting binary string.

First, we must show that the new element is a subset of N .

Clearly it is, since b is an infinite binary string which corresponds to a subset of N .

Now suppose b were the

n th binary string.

This cannot be the case though, since the n th bit of b differs from the n th bit of the diagonal

(the bits are flipped). 所以 it's 非 on our list, 但是 it should

be, 因为 we assumed that the list enumerated all

possible subsets of N .

Thus we have a contradiction, implying that $P(N)$ is uncountable.

因此 我们有 seen that the cardinality of $P(N)$ (the power 集合 of

the natural numbers) is strictly larger

than the cardinality of N itself. The cardinality of N is denoted

(pronounced "aleph null"), while that of

$P(N)$ is denoted $2^{|N|}$.

It turns out that in fact $P(N)$ has the same cardinality as $\mathbb{R}$ (the real numbers),

和

indeed as the 实数 numbers in $[0,1]$. This cardinality is known as c , the “cardinality of the continuum.” 所以
we know that $2^0 = c$
0
.
Even larger infinite cardinalities (或 “orders of infinity”), denoted
1
,
2
,...,
can be defined using the machinery of 集合 theory; these obey
(to the uninitiated somewhat bizarre) rules of
arithmetic.
Several fundamental questions in modern mathematics concern these objects.
For example, the
famous “continuum hypothesis” asserts that $c =$
(which is equivalent to saying that there are no sets with
1
cardinality strictly between that of the natural numbers and that of the real numbers).
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